would prevent this. Delhi had watched with anxiety as senior Chinese policymakers, including Zhou, had visited Pakistan that year. China seemed to be helping Pakistan re-equip its military with the supply of aircraft and tanks and with assistance for new Pakistani divisions.[115] Delhi had also received "hints of nuclear cooperation" following a Pakistani leader's visit to China.[116]

Johnson told Gandhi that she could help stem further Sino-Pakistan ties by improving relations with Islamabad.[117] India-Pakistan talks had stalled, however, with Pakistan insisting on a Kashmir solution first.[118] Rostow and Rusk recommended urging India to negotiate an arms limitation agreement with Pakistan and to "be prepared to listen to the Paks on Kashmir," even if a settlement was unlikely. Johnson approved this proposal and, upset with Pakistan about its coziness with China, he postponed the spare parts supply question.[119]

Food Aid: With Strings or Chains?

Delhi was even more focused on the US approach to its food supply, which would reinforce concerns about US reliability and thus India's dependence on it. With the monsoon failing for a second year in a row in 1966, there was another severe food shortage in India.[120] In the US, the kind of agricultural surpluses that had facilitated (and indeed led to) the PL-480 program were no longer available. Nonetheless, that summer, Agriculture Secretary Orville Freeman recommended that the US should negotiate another PL-480 agreement to meet the shortfall expected later that year since India had "lived up to [its] commitments" made the previous year.[121]

At the end of August, despite an interagency recommendation, Johnson did not give the go-ahead for an agreement.[122] He had lost his enthusiasm for India because of its performance, priorities, and policies. In early September, in the context of the upcoming Indian election in early spring and a potential gap in food supplies, Rostow urged approval. Weeks later, having received no reply, he warned of the impact on "the high-level Indian's view of our dependability." He also said an indefinite delay would give Gandhi's opposition ammunition against her. A couple of weeks later, Rostow again brought up the reliability issue and noted that the "question is whether Mrs. Gandhi can show that US aid pays off or whether her